

FY26, as the books stood in June

Generated 2026-09-02 from `sources/analyses/fy26-closeout.md`. Every figure is recomputed from `sources/data/lunenburg.db` by `scripts/verify_fy26_closeout.py`. A printed page outlives the numbers on it: re-run that script before quoting anything here.

Working state: `notes/HANDOFF.md` carries the current branch and what is established versus assumed.
`CLAUDE.md` carries the rules.

Analysis, 2 September 2026. Every figure recomputed by `scripts/verify_fy26_closeout.py` from `sources/data/lunenburg.db`.

Each section is written twice: **In plain terms** for anyone, and **The evidence** for anyone who wants to check it. The plain version never states anything the evidence does not support.

What this rests on, and what it is not

On 2 September 2026 the Town Manager sent the FY26 year-to-date budget report in two forms, printed and as a spreadsheet. It is the **first account-level general fund expenditure report this project has ever held**. Every prior one was run as a department rollup, which renders the entire school district as a single row.

Here the school department is **258 accounts**, each with an org code, an object code and a description.

Three limits travel with every figure below, and none of them is a technicality.

It is period 12, not period 13 — June, before purchase orders are cleared in the lapse period. The Town Manager put it exactly right in her covering note, and this document borrows her framing rather than inventing a more anxious one:

"This is the current FY26 report — figures likely to continue to adjust as we continue the year-end reconciliation process."

Current, not final. Both halves of that matter. An earlier draft of this document leaned on the second half and let it imply the first was in doubt, which is its own kind of error: a hedge stretched past what the evidence supports reads as "this might be nothing", and it is not.

What can change is bounded. The only money in play is the **\$236,783.89 still encumbered**: at the close each purchase order is either paid, which leaves the unspent figure where it is, or released, which raises it. The department's final figure lands between **\$482,101 and \$718,885**, and only late invoices posted against period 13 could push it lower. In FY25 the same step moved the school figure **up**, from \$582,115.44 to \$603,885.97 — 3.7%, which here would be about \$18,000.

So nothing here is a surplus, and nothing here is provisional in the sense of being doubtful. It is a position, it is a large one, and the close settles the last few percent.

Zero-balance accounts are suppressed. The report was run with Suppress zero bal accts: Y. An account absent from it is not necessarily absent from the ledger, and nothing below reasons from what is missing.

It is expenditures only, Fund 0100. No grants, no revolving funds, no school choice. The district's budget is *net* — a line is what the town must raise after other money has paid for part of the thing — so none of this says what anything costs.

In one page

The headline number is real and it does not mean what it sounds like. The school department finished June \$482,101 under budget. That is not half a million pounds of slack sitting in a drawer — it is what is left after \$1,683,534 of underspending across 160 accounts is netted against \$1,201,434 of overspending across 56. Roughly \$2.9 million of variance in a \$26.3 million budget, cancelling down to 1.8%.

These figures are current rather than final, and this document holds them the way the Town Manager did when she sent them: *"This is the current FY26 report — figures likely to continue to adjust as we continue the year-end reconciliation process."* That is the right register. They will change. They are also what there is.

What can change is bounded: the **\$236,783.89 still encumbered**. Each purchase order is either paid, leaving the figure where it is, or released, raising it — so the department's final unspent figure lands between **\$482,101 and \$718,885**. In FY25 the same step moved the school figure *up*, by 3.7%.

So "not final" here does not mean "possibly nothing". Around half a million dollars was not spent.

The district spent 97.3% of what it was given. That is the first thing a reader should take from the chart at the top, and it is the ordinary result of a budget that was set about right in total.

What moved is more interesting than what was left. Out-of-district special education tuition swung hardest in both directions: private placements \$522,629 under, collaborative placements \$434,108 over, netting to \$88,522. Electricity ran \$110,338 over. Four special education paraprofessional lines ran \$105,644 over between them.

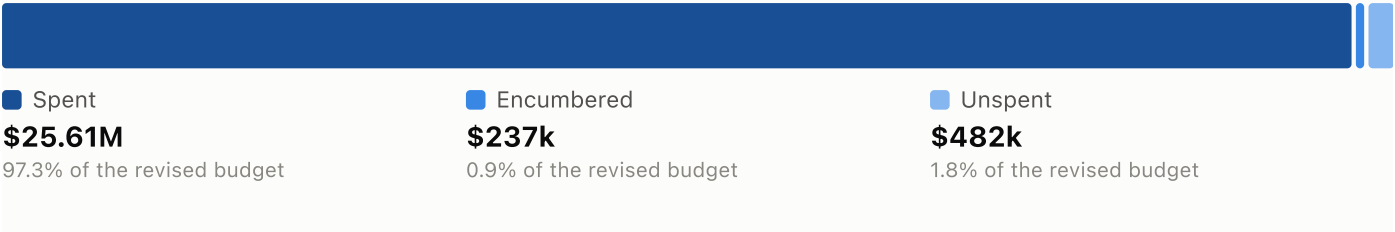
Three things this year cannot explain, and each names the document that would.

1. Kindergarten paraprofessionals were cut to zero in the FY26 approved budget — published openly, at –100% — and \$99,064 was spent on them anyway, with no appropriation and no transfer. Three readings fit and nothing here chooses between them.
2. \$85,090 of budget moved into the department across 82 accounts, and no document in the archive connects any of it to a decision.
3. One of the district's four school psychologist accounts spent nothing all year, while the other three spent theirs in full.

And \$1,736,376 was spent on the schools from funds the budget document cannot see — grants, revolving funds, fees. Not one dollar of it can be attached to a line. Every figure in this document is the town's share, not the cost.

School department: what happened to the budget

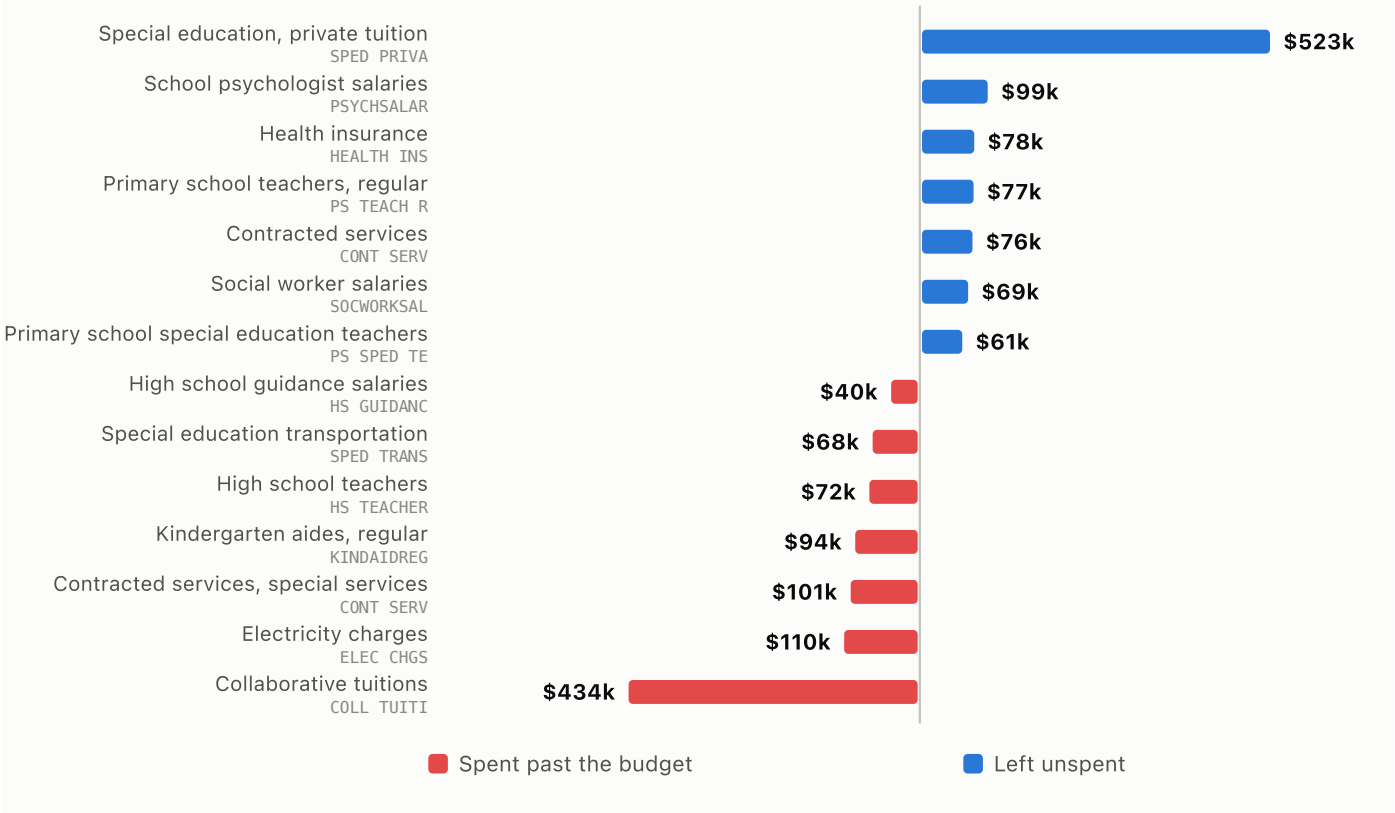
FY2026 at period 12 — the books are not closed, so nothing here is a surplus
Revised budget \$26,332,564



What happened to the FY26 budget. The unspent slice is the one the headline reports, and it is the smallest of the three.

School department: the biggest misses, both directions

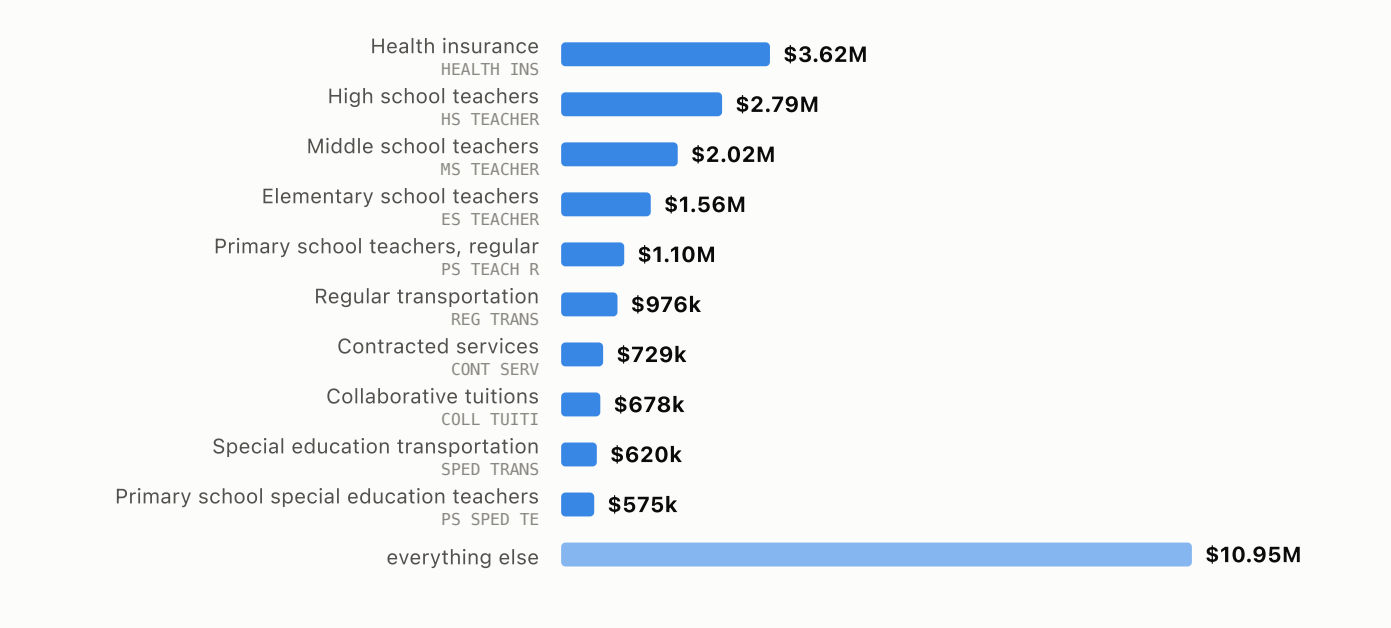
\$1,683,534 left across 160 accounts, \$1,201,434 overspent across 56 — the 7 and 7 largest



The largest misses in both directions. The net figure is the difference between these two arms, not a description of either.

School department: where the money went

The 10 largest accounts by spending, of \$25,613,679 in total



Where the money actually went, largest accounts first.

These three pictures are the whole document in outline. The first shows that almost all of the budget was spent. The second shows that the small leftover is the residue of large movements in both directions. The third shows what the money bought. Everything below is those three facts, itemised and sourced.

1. The headline number is a residual, not a result

IN PLAIN TERMS

The school department was **\$482,101 under budget** in June. That single number is the small remainder of two much larger flows running in opposite directions: about \$1.68 million unspent across 160 accounts, and about \$1.20 million overspent across 56.

Reading \$482,101 as "the schools underspent by half a million" describes the arithmetic correctly and the year not at all.

THE EVIDENCE

Original appropriation	\$26,247,474.00
Transfers and adjustments	\$85,090.24
Revised budget	\$26,332,564.24
Expended	\$25,613,679.23
Encumbered	\$236,783.89
Unspent	\$482,101.12

	ACCOUNTS	AMOUNT
Under their revised budget	160	\$1,683,534.14
Over their revised budget	56	\$1,201,433.65
Net	258	\$482,101.12

Town-wide at the same period: \$51,189,965.10 appropriated, \$2,826,046.42 transferred, \$52,163,984.85 spent, \$529,325.69 encumbered, **\$1,322,700.98 unspent.**

The Town's own release of 1 September 2026 put the school figure at "approximately \$470,000 to \$600,000" and the town-wide figure at "roughly \$1.63 million". The school figure here sits inside that range near the bottom. **The town-wide figures differ and are not reconciled here** — the release is preliminary, this is one report at one period, and nothing published says how the release's figure was struck.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW

Whether any of it survives the close. Encumbrances of \$236,783.89 are still open, and clearing purchase orders releases some of that back and commits the rest.

2. The biggest movers

IN PLAIN TERMS

Two out-of-district special education lines account for most of the movement in both directions, and they move opposite ways. Beneath them sit one of the district's four psychologist accounts that spent nothing all year, a utility overrun, and paraprofessional lines that all ran over.

THE EVIDENCE

ACCOUNT		REVISED	SPENT	ENCUMBERED	LEFT
S0511062	SPED PRIVA — out-of-district, private	\$988,630	\$466,001	\$0	+\$522,629
S5511062	COLL TUITI — out-of-district, collaborative	\$302,663	\$678,062	\$58,708	-\$434,108
S3991742	ELEC CHGS — electricity	\$271,132	\$319,109	\$62,362	-\$110,338
S1511062	CONT SERV — special services contracted	\$105,500	\$204,758	\$1,262	-\$100,520
S2072061	PSYCHSALAR — one of four psychologist accounts, \$4	\$98,784	\$0	\$0	+\$98,784
S2032121	KINDAIDREG — kindergarten paras	\$0	\$93,691	\$0	-\$93,691
S3991692	SPED TRANS — special ed transport	\$565,735	\$620,025	\$13,265	-\$67,555
4 accounts	special education paraprofessionals	\$1,352,508	\$1,458,152	\$0	-\$105,644

The last column is revised – spent – encumbered, **not** revised – spent, and the encumbrance column is printed because without it the arithmetic does not appear to work. COLL TUITI is the clearest case: \$302,663 – \$678,062 is \$375,399, and the figure is \$434,108, because \$58,708 is committed under purchase orders that have not yet been paid. An earlier version of this table showed the variance and omitted the encumbrance it was computed from.

An encumbrance is money promised under a signed contract and not yet paid out. At the year-end close some of it is paid and the rest is released back, which is exactly the step this report predates.

The two out-of-district lines together: \$1,291,293 budgeted, \$1,144,063 spent, a net of +\$88,522.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW

Why the two out-of-district lines moved in opposite directions. It is tempting to read a shift from private placements toward collaboratives. That precise inference — two budget lines moving in opposite directions by similar amounts — is one of the three errors CLAUDE.md records as having shipped here before being caught. What is established is the two numbers. Placement counts by year are not published, so dollars cannot distinguish fewer children from a different mix from a differently struck budget.

Whether the special education paraprofessional overruns mean more staff. They are dollars. A budget line is not a filled position.

3. Kindergarten paraprofessionals — an open question

IN PLAIN TERMS

The FY26 approved budget cut the kindergarten paraprofessional line to zero and published it as a **–100% cut**. During FY26, **\$99,064 was spent on kindergarten paraprofessionals anyway**, against an appropriation of nothing and with no transfer covering it. In February 2026, while that spending was happening, the district

asked for a kindergarten paraprofessional back as a **new** staffing request for FY27, at \$22,205. It did not make the FY27 proposed budget.

No meeting document connects either the cut or the spending to a decision. Kindergarten paraprofessionals do appear in the minutes — twice — and both times as an FY27 staffing request, never in relation to FY26. The distinction matters and an earlier draft of this section did not make it.

This is not presented as an impropriety. Money is routinely spent and reconciled later through a year-end transfer, and the FY26 transfer schedule is exactly what we do not have.

THE EVIDENCE

The cut, published. FY26 School Committee approved budget, 12 March 2025, page 7, under 2330 – Paraprofessionals General Education:

Kindergarten Paraprofessionals	77,699.88\$	73,273.00\$	(73,273.00)\$	-100.00%	(73,273.00)\$
-100.00%					
H.S. Paraprofessionals /Regular	18,435.23\$	47,960.00\$	(47,960.00)\$	-100.00%	(47,960.00)\$
-100.00%					

The history, from the FY27 workbook (fy27-proposals.xlsx, sheet FY27 Budget Projection, and identical in its traceable twin):

CELL		VALUE
C332	FY23 actual	\$75,501.66
D332	FY24 actual	\$77,699.88
E332	FY25 actual	\$83,765.97
F332	FY25 budget	\$73,273.00
G332	FY26 final budget	-
J332 – M332	every FY27 proposal	-

Row 333, Kindergarten Aides/Regular, exists only from FY26: G333 = 0, H333 = 59,709.10 of actuals to date. **That row is the ledger account surfacing in the workbook, not a renamed budget line** — it does not appear in the FY26 approved budget at all.

The spending, from the ledger at period 12:

ACCOUNT	OBJECT	ORIGINAL	TRANSFERS	REVISED	SPENT
S2032121 KINDAIDREG	511103	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$93,691.03
S2032131 KINDPARREG	511203	\$0	\$0	\$0	\$5,373.12

\$99,064.15 against an appropriation of \$0.

The mechanism exists and was used elsewhere. Nine school accounts spent with no original appropriation. Six received a transfer to cover it — HS GUID SE \$42,967, DUES/FEES \$29,965, PHYS ED SU \$550

among them. These two received nothing.

The request, in the minutes. Finance Committee, 26 February 2026, under *Staffing Increase Requests — Primary School*:

1 Interventionist to address the early literacy and math gaps: \$72,441
1 Kindergarten Paraprofessional: \$22,205

and, in the same list, "*The above listed position costs do not include insurance costs.*" A resident named the same request in public comment to the School Committee on 10 March 2026.

Both mentions are FY27 requests. Neither refers to the FY26 cut or to the FY26 spending. That is the whole of what the minutes say.

A PARTIAL CONCLUSION, OFFERED AS ONE

The service continued. Kindergarten paraprofessionals were paid throughout FY26 at a level comparable to prior years — \$99,064 against actuals of \$75,502, \$77,700 and \$83,766 in the three years before — while the line carrying them was budgeted at zero.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW, AND THREE READINGS THAT FIT EQUALLY WELL

1. **A recoding.** The appropriation landed under a different line and the spending did not follow it. **H.S. Paraprofessionals /Regular** was cut the same way and shows *no* FY26 spending, so the cut was real somewhere; it is not established that it was real here.
2. **A grant expected to cover it.** The Town has stated that about \$287,000 of out-of-district tuition was charged to the FY26 IDEA grant rather than the operating budget, so grant-shifting demonstrably happened in FY26. Nothing links it to this line.
3. **An unreconciled overrun** awaiting the year-end transfer that has not yet been voted.

Do not treat the \$22,205 request as the cost of the FY26 spending. It is one position, excluding insurance, in a different fiscal year. $\$99,064 \div \$22,205$ is arithmetic, not a headcount.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

The FY26 year-end transfer schedule, by department and account, with the authority for each. And Finance Committee minutes from 14 July 2026 onward.

4. Four psychologist lines, and one of them spent nothing

IN PLAIN TERMS

The district carries four school psychologist accounts and four social worker accounts, one per building. **Three of the four psychologist lines spent their budget in full or a little over. The fourth spent nothing at all, all year — \$98,784 budgeted, \$0 out.**

The social worker lines are less stark but point the same way: two spent in full, one spent 68%, one spent 23%.

Between them the eight accounts left \$194,718 unspent, which is about 40% of the department's entire net underspend.

THE EVIDENCE

ACCOUNT		BUDGETED	SPENT	
S2044061	PSYCHSALAR	\$98,784	\$101,510	103%
S2055061	PSYCHSALAR	\$45,106	\$45,306	100%
S2066061	PSYCHSALAR	\$45,106	\$45,306	100%
S2072061	PSYCHSALAR	\$98,784	\$0	0%
four psychologist accounts		\$287,780	\$192,122	
S2044651	SOCWORKSAL	\$92,939	\$92,939	100%
S2055651	SOCWORKSAL	\$92,939	\$63,214	68%
S2066651	SOCWORKSAL	\$90,212	\$20,877	23%
S2072651	SOCWORKSAL	\$92,939	\$92,939	100%
four social worker accounts		\$369,029	\$269,969	

All eight carry object code 511023 or 511024, and none received a transfer.

WHY IT MATTERS BEYOND THE MONEY

CLAUDE.md lists as a standing question: *"Whether budgeted positions were filled. A budget line is an intention."* For these eight lines, in this one year, the ledger comes closer to answering it than anything this project has held before — three lines paid in full look like filled posts, and one paid nothing does not.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW

That a post was vacant. A line spending nothing is consistent with a vacancy, with a person paid from a different account, with a grant-funded position, or with a coding change. Rule 7: the measurement is the dollars.

And it is deliberately not stated as "a school psychologist was cut". An earlier draft of this section quoted the zero line alone and described it as *a position budgeted and not spent*, which read as a statement

about the district's psychologists in general. It is one of four. `scripts/verify_fy26_closeout.py` caught it because the figure it derived from the database did not match the figure in the prose.

5. \$85,090 moved into the schools — what that actually looks like

IN PLAIN TERMS

"\$85,090 of transfers" is not one movement. It is **82 separate account changes**: 49 accounts had budget added, 33 had budget taken away, and the difference between those two piles is \$85,090.

Most of it is the department moving its own money around during the year — an overrun here covered by an underspend there. The net is what came from outside the department.

And the ledger cannot tell you what any transfer was from. It records that an account's budget changed. It does not record the counterparty. That is in the transfer schedule, and the transfer schedule is what the Finance Committee twice did not have.

THE EVIDENCE

	ACCOUNTS	AMOUNT
Budget added	49	\$394,928.82
Budget taken away	33	\$309,838.58
Net into the department	82	\$85,090.24

The largest movements in each direction:

ACCOUNT		CHANGE	ORIGINAL
S0990991 SCHSALRESE	school salary reserve	−\$90,769.62	\$90,770
S2516061 HS SPED RE	H.S. special ed	−\$81,075.96	\$449,087
S2066651 HS GUID SE	H.S. guidance	+\$42,966.92	\$0
S2514131 ESSPEDPARA	E.S. special ed paras	+\$33,623.36	\$225,152
S0011742 CONT SERV	contracted services	+\$31,291.13	\$257,000
S3066672 DUES/FEES	athletics dues and fees	+\$29,965.45	\$0
S2055711 MS REG SUB	M.S. substitutes	+\$21,230.45	\$11,000
S3066672 ATH INS	athletics insurance	−\$20,000.00	\$29,000
S2032711 KIND LONG	kindergarten long-term subs	−\$15,000.00	\$15,000

What a transfer looks like, read off this table. S0990991 SCHSALRESE is a *salary reserve* — a contingency line budgeted at \$90,770 and deliberately not attached to any job. Over the year it gave up **every dollar**, ending

at zero. That is a reserve doing exactly what a reserve is for. S2032711 KIND LONG gave up its whole \$15,000 the same way, and S2516061 gave up \$81,076 of a \$449,087 special education line.

On the other side, HS GUID SE and DUES/FEES both started at \$0 and were given \$42,967 and \$29,965 — accounts that had no budget until money was moved into them. Which is precisely what did *not* happen for the kindergarten paraprofessional accounts in §3.

WHERE THE NET \$85,090 CAME FROM

Not established. Town-wide, net transfers into the general fund at period 12 are \$2,826,046.42 — so this is not a closed system in which one department's gain is another's loss. The town's SALARY RESERVE department gave up \$128,953.67, and the capital projects and trust fund transfer accounts took in \$1,240,820.32 and \$795,437.00. Whether any of the school department's \$85,090 came from the salary reserve, from a Town Meeting vote, or from somewhere else **cannot be read off this report**, because the report shows each account's net change and never its counterparty.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW

That no vote happened. Minutes may not be posted yet, and not every transfer requires a Finance Committee vote. What can be said is that **no document in this archive connects any of these 82 movements to a decision.**

Finance Committee, 11 June 2026:

"a. Year End Transfers — The documents needed on this topic were not provided but should be available for the next meeting."

It returned to the agenda for 14 July 2026. The archive holds Finance Committee **agendas** through 27 August 2026 and **minutes** only through 11 June 2026.

6. The money that never appears in the budget at all

IN PLAIN TERMS

Alongside the general fund, the schools ran **21 other funds that spent money** in FY26 — grants, revolving funds fed by fees, and gifts. Together they spent **\$1,736,376**, and not one dollar of it appears in the district's budget document.

The largest is school lunch, which is a self-contained operation. But the next several are not: **\$409,035 of IDEA special education grants**, \$233,350 of extended day, \$100,467 of athletics, \$95,196 of after-school.

THE EVIDENCE

These figures are period 9 — through 31 March 2026 — not period 12. They come from a different report from everything above, and the two cannot be added into a single year-end total. Where §1 says "period

12", this section says "through March".

FUND		REVENUE IN	SPENT	BALANCE
2200	School Lunch Revolving	\$572,231	\$739,586	\$287,771
1312	Extended Day Revolving	\$192,943	\$233,350	\$54,161
2813	FY25 IDEA #240	\$0	\$229,398	-\$88,503
2814	FY26 IDEA #240	\$0	\$179,637	-\$179,637
1301	Chapter 658 (athletics)	\$160,164	\$100,467	\$169,945
1305	After School Activities	\$111,376	\$95,196	\$148,578
2778	FY25 SOA Evidence-Based	\$0	\$68,647	-\$91,220
1308	School Choice Revolving	\$83,116	\$30,558	\$299,461
2672	FY26 Family & Community #237	\$48,558	\$13,372	\$35,186
1306	School Facilities Use	\$18,670	\$12,354	\$71,559
2640	Special Ed Circuit Breaker	\$325,970	\$4,005	\$615,301
1311	School Gift Fund	\$22,486	\$2,911	\$109,398
	ten smaller funds		\$26,896	
	total		\$1,736,376	

TWO THINGS IN THAT TABLE WORTH READING TWICE

The IDEA grants spent \$409,035 between them and took in nothing, ending at -\$88,503 and -\$179,637. A negative balance here means spending has run ahead of the reimbursement drawn down; grants are typically claimed in arrears. It is not an overdraft.

Special education circuit breaker took in \$325,970 and spent \$4,005, holding **\$615,301**. Circuit breaker is the state's reimbursement toward high-cost out-of-district placements — the same thing §2's two tuition lines pay for. That is a large balance sitting beside a general fund tuition line that underspent by \$522,629.

Nothing here links them. No document maps a fund's spending onto a budget line, so it cannot be said that circuit breaker money did or did not pay for a placement the general fund budgeted. The two facts sit next to each other and that is all.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW — AND IT IS THE WHOLE OF §6

Where any of this money went. The fund tells you its purpose, not the line it paid. School lunch plainly buys food; the IDEA grants plainly buy special education; but *which* special education — which staff, which placement, which of the 258 accounts it would otherwise have shown up in — is not published anywhere.

So every figure in sections 1 to 5 is the **town's share**. A line that fell may mean less service, or may mean one of these funds paid for it. The expense side cannot tell them apart, and neither can this document.

7. Money not spent on people — the closest we can get

IN PLAIN TERMS

The Town's own explanation for the FY25 surplus was **unfilled posts**: *"significant turnover and unfilled positions in the facilities department resulted in unspent salaries and stalled maintenance projects."* So the obvious question for FY26 is how much of the underspend is salary money that was budgeted for someone and not paid to anyone.

The answer is a ceiling, not a measurement, and the two must not be confused.

Salary accounts that came in under budget hold **\$573,623** — that is the most that could possibly be unfilled-post savings. But salary accounts that went *over* hold \$399,162, so the **net** left on personnel is **\$174,460**, about 36% of the department's net underspend.

Only **three** salary accounts of any size spent nothing at all, and they hold **\$125,239** between them.

THE EVIDENCE

	ACCOUNTS	AMOUNT
Salary accounts under budget	42	\$573,623
Salary accounts over budget	38	\$399,162
Net left on salaries	80	\$174,460

Salary accounts that spent **nothing all year**, above \$5,000:

ACCOUNT		BUDGET	SPENT
<u>S2072061</u>	PSYCHSALAR — school psychologist salaries	\$98,784	\$0
<u>S3066671</u>	ATHSEC — athletics secretary	\$20,407	\$0
<u>S2996101</u>	CCLT/CCL	\$6,048	\$0

Seven more spent nothing and hold \$4,644 between them. **Five of those seven are \$800 secretarial overtime lines**, where spending nothing means no overtime was worked — not a vacancy. That is why the count matters less than it looks.

Salary accounts that spent **less than 85%** of their budget:

ACCOUNT		BUDGET	SPENT		LEFT
S2066651	SOCWORKSAL — social worker salaries	\$90,212	\$20,877	23%	\$69,335
S2055651	MS GUIDANC — middle school guidance	\$131,509	\$97,988	75%	\$33,521
S2055651	SOCWORKSAL — social worker salaries	\$92,939	\$63,214	68%	\$29,725
S2016081	HS ADM SEC — high school admin secretary	\$51,973	\$38,249	74%	\$13,724
S2514711	ES SPED SU — elementary special ed substitutes	\$18,393	\$10,697	58%	\$7,696
	six more under 85%				\$15,220

THE FY25 EXPLANATION DOES NOT REPEAT IN FY26

The Town named **the facilities department**. Whichever facilities it meant, neither shows the pattern in FY26.

The town's Facilities & Grounds salary accounts spent **100% of budget, to the dollar**: DIR FAC SA \$68,966 of \$68,966, SAL STAFF \$46,772 of \$46,772, SALFACDIRE \$123,250 of \$123,250, nothing left on any of them. The school's own custodial and maintenance salary lines are at or **over** budget — MTC SYSTEM spent \$262,082 against \$261,711, primary school custodians \$102,733 against \$99,711.

So the mechanism the Town identified for FY25 is not what happened in FY26. Something else produced this year's underspend.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW, AND IT IS MOST OF WHAT A READER WANTS

That any post was vacant. A salary line spending nothing is *consistent with* a vacancy and equally consistent with: the person being paid from a different account, the post being grant-funded, the line being left in the budget after the post was eliminated, or a coding change. Section 4's four psychologist accounts are the clearest case — three paid in full and one paid nothing — and even there the ledger says dollars, not people.

And a partial spend is weaker evidence still. 75% of a salary is equally consistent with a post filled in October, a resignation in April, a part-time appointment, or a person appointed at a lower step. Nothing here separates them.

A budget line is not a position. That is rule 7 and it applies with full force here: the quantity nobody publishes is a headcount, and the quantity we have is dollars.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

A list of budgeted positions with their fill dates — the standing question `notes/DATA-WANTED.md` calls unanswerable. Failing that, the **payroll register by account**, which would show whether a line paid a person for part of the year or nobody at all. Neither is a report the town publishes.

8. Which lines give their money away

IN PLAIN TERMS

A line that is budgeted high and then hands its money to something else is doing the job of a contingency without being called one. Whether that is happening here is a fair question, and this is the year it first became askable — but **one year cannot answer it**.

In FY26, **33 school accounts gave up \$309,839** of budget. Nearly a third of that is one account doing exactly what it exists to do.

THE EVIDENCE

The accounts that gave away the largest share of what they started with:

ACCOUNT		STARTED WITH	GAVE UP		LEFT	SPENT
S0990991	SCHSALRESE — school salary reserve	\$90,770	-\$90,770	100%	\$0	\$0
S2032711	KIND LONG — kindergarten long-term subs	\$15,000	-\$15,000	100%	\$0	\$0
S2066711	HS LONG TE — high school long-term subs	\$3,000	-\$2,956	99%	\$44	\$0
S3066672	ATH INS — athletics insurance	\$29,000	-\$20,000	69%	\$9,000	\$8,980
S2022711	PS LONG SU — primary long-term subs	\$15,000	-\$7,075	47%	\$7,925	\$10,265
S1011022	DUES/MTGS — dues and meetings	\$8,000	-\$3,585	45%	\$4,415	\$3,521
S2032711	KIND SUBS — kindergarten substitutes	\$4,000	-\$1,601	40%	\$2,399	\$2,399

READING IT

The largest is a declared contingency and should not be counted as padding. SCHSALRESE is a salary reserve — budgeted at \$90,770, attached to no post, and voted on that basis. Giving away every dollar is the whole point of it. It is 29% of everything the department gave up.

Three of the top five are substitute-teacher lines. KIND LONG, HS LONG TE and PS LONG SU are long-term substitute budgets that gave up 100%, 99% and 47%. A substitute line is a genuine forecast — you budget for absences you cannot predict — so it is the kind of line most likely to be set high and released. It is also the kind of line where "set high" and "set honestly" look identical from outside.

And ATH INS gave up \$20,000 of a \$29,000 insurance budget and then spent \$8,980 of the \$9,000 left. That is a line that turned out to need a third of what it was given.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT SHOW, AND IT IS THE WHOLE LIMITATION

That any of this is consistent. Establishing that a line is *habitually* over-budgeted takes several years of the same account. **This project holds exactly one year at account level** — FY26 at period 12 — so every figure above is a single observation. A line that gave away 100% once may do it every year or may have done it once.

CLAUDE.md rule 6 exists for this: a rate off one or two points is not a trend. One point is not even a rate.

And a 100% give-up is often a recoding rather than a release. The town side has the clearest example: SAL ELECTE gave up 97% of \$80,629 while TN CLK SAL in a different department received \$80,629 and spent \$78,466. The Town Clerk's salary moved between lines. Nothing was over-budgeted; something was renamed.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

The FY24 and FY25 reports at the same grain. Three years of the same accounts would turn every row above from an observation into a pattern or a one-off, and it is the same request already outstanding for other reasons. This is the strongest argument yet for asking for the back years rather than only the current one.

What this means

FOR A RESIDENT

Do not read the headline as slack. "The schools came in \$482,101 under" is arithmetically true and tells you almost nothing. The department spent 97.3% of its budget; the leftover is a residue of much larger movements in both directions, and roughly a third of it is salary money on posts that were not filled for all of the year.

Wait for the close before treating any of it as money. These figures are from June with the books open. The FY25 figure moved twice, publicly, a fortnight apart.

The budget you vote on is not what the schools cost. It is the town's share. Another \$1,736,376 came from grants, fees and revolving funds in the same year, and no published document says which lines it paid for. When somebody quotes a budget line as the cost of something, that is the gap they are standing in.

Where there is a real open question, it is a small number and a specific one. The kindergarten paraprofessional case is \$99,064 against a line the district itself published as cut. It deserves an answer; it is not evidence of anything larger, and nothing in this document says it is.

FOR THE SCHOOL COMMITTEE AND THE FINANCE COMMITTEE

The total is a poor control instrument. A department can land within 2% of budget while individual lines miss by hundreds of percent, and this one did. If the Committee wants to see risk building, it needs the quarterly reports during the year, not the closeout after it — and those quarterly reports do not currently reach the archive or, on the evidence of 11 June, always reach the Committee.

Two lines carry most of the volatility and both are special education placements. Private and collaborative tuition moved \$956,737 between them in opposite directions on a combined budget of \$1,291,293. That is the line to watch, and it is the line nobody controls — which is a reason to forecast it better, not a reason to skip it.

The year-end transfer schedule should be a routine published document. Eighty-two school accounts changed budget in FY26 and the ledger never records a counterparty. That is not a criticism of anyone's bookkeeping; it is a gap between what the system records and what a public body needs in order to approve it.

Where the budget did its job, it shows. The salary reserve was budgeted at \$90,770, attached to no post, and distributed in full — a declared contingency working exactly as intended. Facilities spent its salary budget to the dollar. The district's own budget document published the kindergarten cut at –100% rather than burying it.

FOR WHOEVER RUNS A DEPARTMENT

A zero-budget line that spends without a transfer will look unexplained from outside, however ordinary it was. Six school accounts in FY26 spent against no appropriation and were covered by a transfer; two were not, and those two are the only ones anybody has questions about. The difference is a paperwork step, not a spending decision.

Substitute and reserve lines are read differently from everything else, and should be. A long-term substitute budget releasing most of its money is a forecast that came in low, not padding. This document says so explicitly, because the raw ranking would suggest otherwise.

One year cannot show a pattern, in either direction. Nothing here establishes that any line is habitually over- or under-budgeted, and any claim that it does is wrong. Three years at this grain would settle it, and the request is already outstanding.

What would change these findings

In order of how much each would settle:

1. **The FY26 period 13 report.** Turns every figure here from a position into a result.
2. **The year-end transfer schedule,** by account, with authority. Settles §3 and §5.
3. **The same report for funds other than 0100.** Turns the net budget into a gross one.
4. **Finance Committee minutes from 14 July 2026.**
5. **Out-of-district placement counts by year.** The only thing that would let §2's two tuition lines be read as anything other than two numbers.
6. **Budgeted positions with their fill dates, or the payroll register by account.** Turns §7's ceiling into a measurement.
7. **FY24 and FY25 at account level.** §8 can show which lines gave money away once; only three years can show which do it habitually.

How to reproduce

```
python3 scripts/build_db.py
python3 scripts/verify_fy26_closeout.py
```